Lesson 38: Avoiding Plagiarism and Formatting Your Paper

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 4: Research and Evidence

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 4.8 Avoiding Plagiarism; 4.9 Formatting Your Paper.

In this lesson

You learn what counts as plagiarism in U.S. universities, how to show clearly which ideas come from sources, and the difference between a real paraphrase and "patchwriting". You also learn to set up a paper and a Works Cited list in MLA format, and you use both skills in your research project.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Recognize plagiarism, including unintentional plagiarism and self-plagiarism.
- Show whose ideas are whose with in-text citations and a Works Cited list.
- Tell a paraphrase from patchwriting, and write a real paraphrase.
- Set up a paper in MLA format and build MLA Works Cited entries.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
PLA·gi·a·rism	using another person's intellectual material without giving them credit	A student uses a quotation but does not say where it is from.
unintentional	not done on purpose	Unintentional plagiarism is still plagiarism.
in-text citation	the source's name where you use it: in your sentence, or in parentheses at the end of it (a parenthetical citation)	(Cusido)
Works Cited	the MLA list of all the sources you used, at the end of the paper	Vince, Gaia. "Why Being Bilingual ..."
patchwriting	changing some words of a source but keeping many of its words and its structure	"All over the world, over 50% of people ..."
format	the standard way a paper must look	MLA format, APA format
container	the larger work that holds the source	a journal, a newspaper, a website

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
hanging indent	first line at the left margin, the next lines indented ½ inch	used for every Works Cited entry
DOI	digital object identifier: a permanent code for an article	doi:10.1111/dech.12572

Rules and explanations

What is plagiarism?

- Plagiarism is a kind of academic dishonesty (cheating); colleges may discipline or even expel students for it.
- You can plagiarize yourself, by re-using your own work without saying that it has appeared elsewhere.
- Unintentional plagiarism is still plagiarism.
- In some cultures, using the words of others is a sign of honor and respect. U.S. instructors will probably judge your work by American standards, which give high value to using your own words.

How to avoid it

1. Take notes carefully: mark source material in your notes, cite it immediately and add it to your Works Cited list.
2. Give credit with in-text citations whenever you use someone's work.
3. If you are unsure whether something is acceptable, ask your instructor. Studying alone, ask your tutor and read your university's academic integrity policy.

Making sources visible

- **In the text:** name the source where you use it, in your sentence ("As Marco Lopez, an executive at a Chicago marketing agency explains, ...") or in parentheses at the end of the sentence: (Cusido). If the person is quoted in another source, write (qtd. in Cusido).
- **At the end:** list every source in a Works Cited list.

Paraphrase or patchwriting?

- A **paraphrase** rewrites someone's idea in your own words **and** your own sentence structure.
- **Patchwriting** replaces some words with synonyms but keeps many original words and the same structure. It is plagiarism, even with a citation and even if the writer did not mean to plagiarize.
- In the book's example (a quotation from Vince about multilingualism), the patchwriting keeps about half of the original words and exactly the same sentence structure. The real paraphrase ("According to Gaia Vince, while English speakers often speak only one language, it is actually more common to be multilingual ...") changes the words, the order of ideas and the sentences.

MLA and APA

MLA (Modern Language Association) format is used in language, literature and the humanities, and in college English classes. **APA** (American Psychological Association) format is used in the social sciences and in many college courses outside English.

> **Psychology note:** Psychology uses APA style: the list is called References, in-text citations give the author and year (Lee, 2021), and in each entry the year comes right after the author: Lee, C. (2021).

Setting up a paper in MLA format

- Margins of 1 inch on all sides (½ inch for header and footer); a standard 12-point font (Times New Roman is the most common).
- Double spacing throughout, with no extra space between paragraphs; a straight left edge and a "ragged" right edge; paragraphs indented ½ inch (one tab).
- Page 1 only: an upper left heading with your name, the teacher's name, the class and the date, then the title, centered, in plain font (no bold, underlining or italics).
- Every page: an upper right header with your last name and an automatic page number, as in the sample paper "Heritage Languages: the Language of Emotions" (Coelho Silverio 1).

The Works Cited page

- It starts on a new page at the end of the paper, with the title Works Cited centered, in the same format as the paper.
- Sources are in alphabetical order by the first word of each entry, not in the order they appear in the paper.
- Each entry has a hanging indent. Do not break lines, URLs or DOIs by hand; let the word processor do it.

Building an entry (the book's example: Lee's article)

Element	Rule	Example
Author.	Last name, First name. Two authors: Last, First, and First Last. Three or more: Last, First, et al.	Lee, Chaehyun.
"Title of Source."	Capitalize all words except articles, prepositions and coordinating conjunctions such as *and, but, or* (the first and last words always have a capital). Short works (articles, chapters) in quotation marks; whole works (books, films, periodicals, websites) in italics. The period goes inside the quotation marks.	"A Longitudinal Study: Emergent Bilinguals' Heritage Language Use and Learning over Time."

Element	Rule	Example
Container,	the journal, newspaper, website or book that holds the source; italics	*International Online Journal of Primary Education*,
Other contributors,	editors, translators, directors ... (skip if none)	-
Version, Number,	edition; volume "vol." and issue "no." in plain font, lowercase	vol. 10, no. 1,
Publisher,	skip it if it is the same as the container, as for many online sources	-
Date,	day month year; long month names may be abbreviated with a period	30 June 2021,
Location.	pages (p. 6; pp. 184-96; pp. 456-502), or a URL without http://, or a DOI instead of a URL	pp. 1-18, www.iojpe.org/index.php/iojpe/article/view/1/4.

Complete entry: Lee, Chaehyun. "A Longitudinal Study: Emergent Bilinguals' Heritage Language Use and Learning over Time." *International Online Journal of Primary Education*, vol. 10, no. 1, 30 June 2021, pp. 1-18, www.iojpe.org/index.php/iojpe/article/view/1/4.

Corrections to the book's table: its examples show "vol. 1" and "no. 10", but the article is volume 10, issue 1 (as the complete entry shows); "doi" stands for digital object **identifier**, not "indicator"; and for three or more authors, the first author's name is still reversed (Akhter, Sadika, et al.).

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no capital letters, so check every title in your Works Cited list: capitals for the first word, the first word after a colon and all main words; lowercase for articles, prepositions and coordinating conjunctions in the middle (of, and, over). - If you learned to write by memorizing and reproducing model texts, patchwriting can feel natural. In English academic writing it counts as plagiarism, even with a citation.

Practice

Exercise 1. Recognizing plagiarism. Which of the following scenarios show plagiarism? (Remember, even if it's unintentional, it's still plagiarism!)

1. A student finds a great quotation to use in her essay but forgets to indicate where it's from.
2. Three students in a study group turn in the same answers for a set of exercises.
3. Three students in a study group help each other understand the concepts in the unit, but they each turn in their own answers.
4. A student doesn't realize an important assignment is due in class the next day. Fortunately, they completed a similar assignment in a different class last semester, so they turn that one in instead.

Exercise 2. Where do the ideas come from? Read the student paragraph in 4.8 that begins "Being able to speak more than one language opens up more employment opportunities."

1. Which two pieces of information come from an outside source? How can you tell?
2. Find two sentences that are the student's own ideas.

Exercise 3. Paraphrase or patchwriting? Here is a quotation: "Multilingualism has been shown to have many social, psychological and lifestyle advantages. Moreover, researchers are finding a swathe of health benefits from speaking more than one language, including faster stroke recovery and delayed onset of dementia" (Vince). Is this an appropriate paraphrase, or is it plagiarism?

Speaking more than one language has many social, psychological, and lifestyle benefits. In addition, researchers find a lot of health benefits from being multilingual. Those include recovering from strokes and dementia developing later (Vince).

Exercise 4. Write a real paraphrase of the Vince quotation in Exercise 3.

Exercise 5. What goes into the entry? Look at the raw information from the top of Lee's article in 4.9. Which pieces of information are not used in the complete Works Cited entry?

Exercise 6. Build entries. Put the elements in order, with the correct punctuation and italics.

1. an online article: Mosaic (website) / Gaia Vince / mosaicscience.com/bilingual-brains/ / Aug. 2016 / Why Being Bilingual Helps Keep Your Brain Fit
2. an online article: 13 Mar. 2017 / NBCUniversal News Group (publisher) / Carmen Cusido / NBCNews.com (website) / Report: Want the Job? Be Able to Say So in More than One Language
3. Which of the two entries comes first in a Works Cited list?

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is a sentence from my source and my paraphrase: [paste both]. Is it a real paraphrase or patchwriting? Show me which words and structures are too close."
- "Here is my cited paragraph from Lesson 37: [paste]. Is it clear which ideas are mine and which come from sources?"
- "Here is my Works Cited list: [paste]. Check the order, punctuation, italics and capital letters. Then show me the same list in APA style."
- "Let's discuss: how is the U.S. view of plagiarism different from what I learned at school? Ask me questions about my experience, then give me three habits to change."

Writing task

Your research project: citations and a Works Cited list.

1. Take your paragraph from Lesson 37. Check it with the book's questions: Is it clear whose ideas belong to whom? Is each outside source cited? Rewrite any sentence that is patchwriting.
2. Write a Works Cited list in MLA format for the sources in your paragraph and in your annotated bibliography (at least three entries). If the paper is for a psychology course, also make an APA

References list.

3. Put the paragraph into an MLA document: heading, header, title, double spacing, and the Works Cited list on a new page.

Self-editing checklist:

- Every quotation, paraphrase, idea and number from a source has an in-text citation.
- Each paraphrase changes both the words and the sentence structure.
- The Works Cited list is on a new page, with a centered title, alphabetical order and hanging indents.
- Each entry follows the order Author. "Title of Source." *Container*, other elements, Location.
- Article titles are in quotation marks, containers in italics, and the main words have capitals.
- Dates are written day month year; URLs have no http://, and a DOI replaces the URL when there is one.
- The page setup is correct: 1-inch margins, 12-point font, the heading on page 1, my last name and the page number on every page.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Chaehyun Lee's article, used for the Works Cited example: https://www.iojpe.org/index.php/iojpe/article/view/1
- The Word on College Reading and Writing, the open textbook that the book adapted, with more MLA help: https://openoregon.pressbooks.pub/wrd/

Answer key

Exercise 1 (book) Scenarios 1, 2 and 4 would likely be considered plagiarism. In 1 the source is not credited (forgetting is no excuse); in 2 each student presents shared work as their own; 4 is self-plagiarism. In 3 the students only studied together. In a real course, check with your instructor if you are unsure.

Exercise 2

1. The job-posting statistics (introduced with "In an NBC News article, it was reported that", in quotation marks, cited (Cusido)) and Marco Lopez's view that bilingual applicants have advantages in being hired (introduced with "As Marco Lopez, an executive at a Chicago marketing agency explains," and cited (qtd. in Cusido)).
2. Any two of the sentences beginning: "Being able to speak more than one language ..." · "These figures show ..." · "While speaking multiple languages may not be the only criteria ..." · "This shows how simply maintaining connections ..." · "Immigrant parents should be made aware ..." (The second sentence, "With more and more immigrants ...", also has no citation, so it is presented as the student's own reasoning.) Note two language errors in this student paragraph: "who's best language" should be "whose best language", and "the only criteria" should be "the only criterion".

Exercise 3 (book) This is patchwriting, and therefore plagiarism. Although some words have been changed, the sentence structure is very similar to the original, and many words are the same ("social, psychological, and lifestyle", "researchers", "health benefits", "more than one language").

Exercise 4 (example answer) Science editor Gaia Vince reports that research has found many benefits for people who know several languages: they gain socially and psychologically, and in their daily lives. A growing number of studies also connect multilingualism with better health, such as a quicker recovery after a stroke and a later start of dementia.

Exercise 5 The copyright line; the author's degree, job title and university; the ORCID number and email address; the received and accepted dates. (The year 2021 is used, as part of the publication date.)

Exercise 6 (book: these are the entries in the Works Cited list of 4.8)

1. Vince, Gaia. "Why Being Bilingual Helps Keep Your Brain Fit." *Mosaic*, Aug. 2016, mosaicscience.com/bilingual-brains/.
2. Cusido, Carmen. "Report: Want the Job? Be Able to Say So in More than One Language." *NBCNews.com*, NBCUniversal News Group, 13 Mar. 2017.
3. Cusido (alphabetical order: C before V).

My notes